services, at the very least, are turning a blind eye to the traffic, which serves China's geopolitical interests in the region. Apart from sheltering Baruah, Chinese intelligence officers are also known to have visited the camp near Taka on more than one occasion.

The Chinese may not want to set India's northeast ablaze, but it is in Beijing's interest to cause frictions and disruptions in Myanmar's relations with India. Since the suspension of the Myitsone dam project in 2011, Myanmar has distanced itself from its old ally China and established closer contacts not only with the West but also with India. But a closer, more cordial relationship between Myanmar and India is not in China's interest. Instability along the border—rebel raids into India and retaliatory, Indian cross-border attacks—would serve that purpose. It is also to China's advantage that Myanmar's authorities are paying only scant interest to events along the country's western border. It keeps Myanmar closer to China, which has not given up hope of improved relations.

For this and other more compelling reasons such as its own ethnic insurgencies, it is highly unlikely that Myanmar would ever agree to take part in any joint operations with the Indian Army against the rebels from India's northeast. On the formal level, the Myanmar government continues to have a ceasefire agreement with the NSCN-K—and while attacks in India and cross-border raids by the Indian Army into Myanmar were taking place, Khaplang himself was recuperating in a hospital in the old capital, Yangon, where he was visited by Aung Min, then a government minister who was also engaged in ongoing peace talks with Myanmar's many rebel groups.[25]

The borderlands between India and Myanmar are more likely to be the scene for further military action rather than the Himalayas. The only potentially serious conflict on the border between Arunachal and Tibet since the 1962 War began in July 1986, when an Indian patrol found about 40 Chinese soldiers erecting what appeared to be permanent buildings in the Sumdorong Chu Valley, an area which the Indians believed was on their side of the border or straddling it. Reinforcements were sent in to keep an eye on developments and, by August, the Chinese had constructed a helipad in the area.

In order to diffuse the situation, India suggested that if the Chinese vacated the area during the coming winter, Indian troops would not enter it